

Ken Faiman

Senior / Lead / Principal Technical Artist · Character & Simulation Specialist

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Demo Reel: [faiman.com](https://www.faiman.com) · **Portfolio:** [Rigging](#) / [sim](#) / [modular build breakdown](#)

SUMMARY

- Technical Artist with 25 years on character and simulation: rigging, cloth/hair/skin simulation, facial and performance capture, deformation, and the avatar/character pipelines that ship them.
- Facial capture on *The Matrix* films, a decade of character FX at DreamWorks, seven years leading rigging and simulation on Blizzard cinematics, and real-time avatar systems at Meta Reality Labs.
- Most recently at Meta (Meta Avatars / Horizon), built the avatar auto-rigging, deformation, skinning, and blueprint systems for a shipped real-time platform, and led the Avatar Hair team behind its universal hair rig.
- Member, The Animation Guild (IATSE TAG Local 839).

CORE COMPETENCIES

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| • Character rigging & auto-rigging | • Standardized skeleton naming |
| • Autofit deformation & attribute transfer | • Node/graph ("blueprint") avatar logic |
| • Skinning, blendshapes & deformers | • Modular avatar/character pipelines |
| • Cloth / hair / skin / feather simulation | • USD / asset pipelines |
| • Facial and performance capture | • Pipeline automation and validation |
| • LODs & game-engine optimization | • Python tooling |
| • Real-time rigging and animation systems | • Cross-discipline leadership and enablement |

EXPERIENCE

Meta, Reality Labs · Senior Technical Artist (IC5), Avatar Rigging & Simulation 2022–2026

Character and avatar systems for Meta Avatars and Horizon, a shipped real-time VR/mobile avatar platform.

- Built and maintained the core avatar rigging and deformation systems in a production real-time game engine: auto-rigging, autofit deformation, attribute transfer, skinning, and blendshapes, with standardized skeleton-naming conventions across the pipeline.
- Built node/graph ("blueprint"-style) systems for the parametric avatar backend and for clothing-rig automation, and optimized runtime deformation (geometric deformers, LODs, runtime motion, modular asset integration) for game-engine performance within hard VR and mobile budgets.
- As lead of the Avatar Hair team, created the universal hair rig, built the grooming/authoring pipeline behind it, and trained and supervised a team of 10+ artists authoring 200+ dynamic hairstyles.
- Rated "Exceeded Expectations" in the most recent year-end review for technical contributions and leadership.

Blizzard Entertainment, Cinematics · Senior Rigging & Simulation Artist II (Lead) 2015–2022

Rigging and simulation lead across World of Warcraft, Overwatch, Diablo, Heroes of the Storm, and Hearthstone cinematics.

- Built complete character rigs for cinematics across five franchises: full-body, facial, clothing, and hair setups, from skeleton and controls through deformation.
- Architected modular, graph-based build components (Python rig modules) deployed across all cinematic pipelines, and built PyQt-based artist tools for the studio's modular rigging/simulation builder.
- Built the nCloth/nHair simulation methodology and tools adopted across five franchises, and owned character rigging and shot simulation on 25+ cinematics from functional setup through production-final.

DreamWorks Animation · Character Effects Artist / Senior Cloth Developer 2005–2015

Character FX (cloth, hair, skin) on hero characters across eight feature films.

- Hero-character cloth, hair, and skin on *How to Train Your Dragon*, *Puss in Boots*, *Kung Fu Panda*, *Bee Movie*, *Over the Hedge*, *Turbo*, *Penguins of Madagascar*, and *Home*.
- Pioneered cloth-based skin solvers for hero characters (e.g. Stoick in *How to Train Your Dragon*, Puss in Boots).

Rhythm & Hues Studios · Motion Capture TD / VFX Motion Editor 2004–2005

- Visual-effects motion editing on *The Chronicles of Narnia: The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe*.

ESC Entertainment · Facial Capture / FX Technical Director

2002–2004

Universal Capture facial system for the Matrix films.

- Facial rigging, sculpting, match-move, texture projection, and compositing on the Universal Capture facial system for *The Matrix Reloaded* and *The Matrix Revolutions*; also *Catwoman* and *The Ladykillers*.
- Part of the team behind the award-winning Universal Capture facial system (Academy Sci-Tech / VES recognition, team award). Contributed work to multiple SIGGRAPH presentations, including "Making of The Superpunch" (2004).

Earlier: Activision · 3D Game Artist (2000).

SKILLS

- **Disciplines:** Character rigging, cloth/hair/skin/feather simulation, grooming, facial and performance capture, deformation (skinning, blendshapes, geometric deformers), avatar/character pipelines, pipeline automation, look-dev
- **Code:** Python, OpenMaya API, MEL, C++ (modern C++17), C#
- **DCC / Tools:** Maya, Houdini, USD/OpenUSD, VS Code
- **Engines / Real-time:** Production real-time game-engine systems (auto-rigging, autofit deformation, skinning/blendshapes, node/graph "blueprint" avatar logic, clothing-rig automation, deformers, LODs, modular asset integration), Unity (soft-body dynamics game development), Unreal Engine (Blueprint + MCP integration), Maya node-graph workflows
- **AI / ML:** Agentic AI frameworks and custom agent tooling (Claude Code, OpenClaw), MCP/RAG, multi-agent orchestration, Unreal MCP, genAI asset CI (validation / USD conversion / compliance), AI enablement and TA training

SELECTED CREDITS

- **Feature VFX:** *The Matrix Reloaded*, *The Matrix Revolutions* (2003) · *Catwoman*, *The Ladykillers* (2004) · *Narnia: LWW* (2005)
- **Feature animation (DreamWorks):** *Over the Hedge*, *Bee Movie*, *Kung Fu Panda*, *How to Train Your Dragon*, *Puss in Boots*, *Turbo*, *Penguins of Madagascar*, *Home* (2006–2015)
- **Games cinematics (Blizzard):** *World of Warcraft*, *Overwatch*, *Diablo*, *Heroes of the Storm*, *Hearthstone* (2015–2022)
- **VR:** avatar/character systems for *Meta Avatars* and *Horizon* at *Meta Reality Labs* (2022–2026)

PIPELINE & TOOLING DIFFERENTIATOR

A character/simulation TA who also builds the production tooling the art team adopts.

- **Asset-pipeline tooling (C++):** Built a thread-optimized C++ library converting FBX to engine-compliant USD with full validation and automatic non-compliance fixing, shipped as both a CLI and a CI-pipeline node, running across 100,000s of vendor and genAI assets.
- Built a fully multi-threaded, CPU-based **HdStorm + Vulkan** system in **OpenUSD** for direct **PBR renders** on devservers: **10k USD assets per batch**, headless and at scale.
- **Agentic AI tooling:** Built custom agent frameworks (Claude Code) and trained Technical Artists to adopt agentic workflows in production; personal R&D in multi-agent orchestration, MCP/GPU-RAG (**mainframe-mcp**, open source, github.com/sushiHex), and diffusion fine-tuning (LoRA on FLUX), all with tests and CI.

EDUCATION

- **UCLA:** B.A., Film, Television & Animation
- **Gnomon School of Visual Effects:** Maya